appreciated entertainment was afforded by the Bahurupi, whose performance included startlingly accurate mimicry of people and animals. ‘Youths disguised themselves as old men so successfully,’ marvelled Abu’l Fazl, ‘that they impose upon the most acute observers.’ All those who presented themselves were given gifts, wine, and a banquet of food and, not surprisingly, throngs of people jostled to view the extravagant affair and ‘whole communities of jogis arrived, with their chiefs’. Monserrate was astonished to note that these jogis ‘profanely and frivolously laid aside all pretense of piety, danced impudently and shamelessly, and fulsomely flattered the King in the songs they sang’. Women were allowed into the palaces and were taken to see the beautiful decorations inside and they may even have witnessed the dance performances of the celebrated Kanchani. These were dancers of the Kanjari caste to whom Akbar had given the title Kanchani, or gilded, and who performed for the ladies of the harem. According to the later French traveller Bernier, ‘most of these kenchens are handsome and well dressed, and sing to perfection; and their limbs being extremely supple, they dance with wonderful agility, and are always correct in regard to time’.

Another ceremony that may have originated from Persian precedents of Nauroz in the reign of Shah Ismail took place at this time. This ceremony involved weighing the emperor at the beginning of the solar year. Other scholars see in this tuladan a revival of old Hindu customs. This ceremony, begun in the time of Humayun but gaining in importance only under Akbar, became very elaborate during the reigns of future Padshahs. On both his lunar and solar birthdays, Akbar was weighed against twelve articles such as gold, quicksilver, silk, perfumes, copper, ruh-i-tutiya[*], drugs,[†] ghee, iron, rice-milk, and seven types of grains and salt. Once he had been weighed, the articles were distributed among the needy, both Hindus and Muslims.

On each day of the Nauroz, Akbar went to the tent of a select nobleman and was entertained lavishly by him. These privileged amirs would have demanded the very best banquets for the Padshah from their cooks and there would have been kebabs, marinated meats of all kinds, and elaborately spiced vegetables. Perhaps some of the Rajput noblemen would have been aware of the *Ksemakutuhalam* (Diet and Well-Being), written for a Rajput ruler in 1550, which listed a veritably overwhelming selection of meats that could be cooked for a king including boar, lamb, goat, venison, rabbit, lizard, pig, peacock, tortoise, and a variety of game birds. In addition, it was